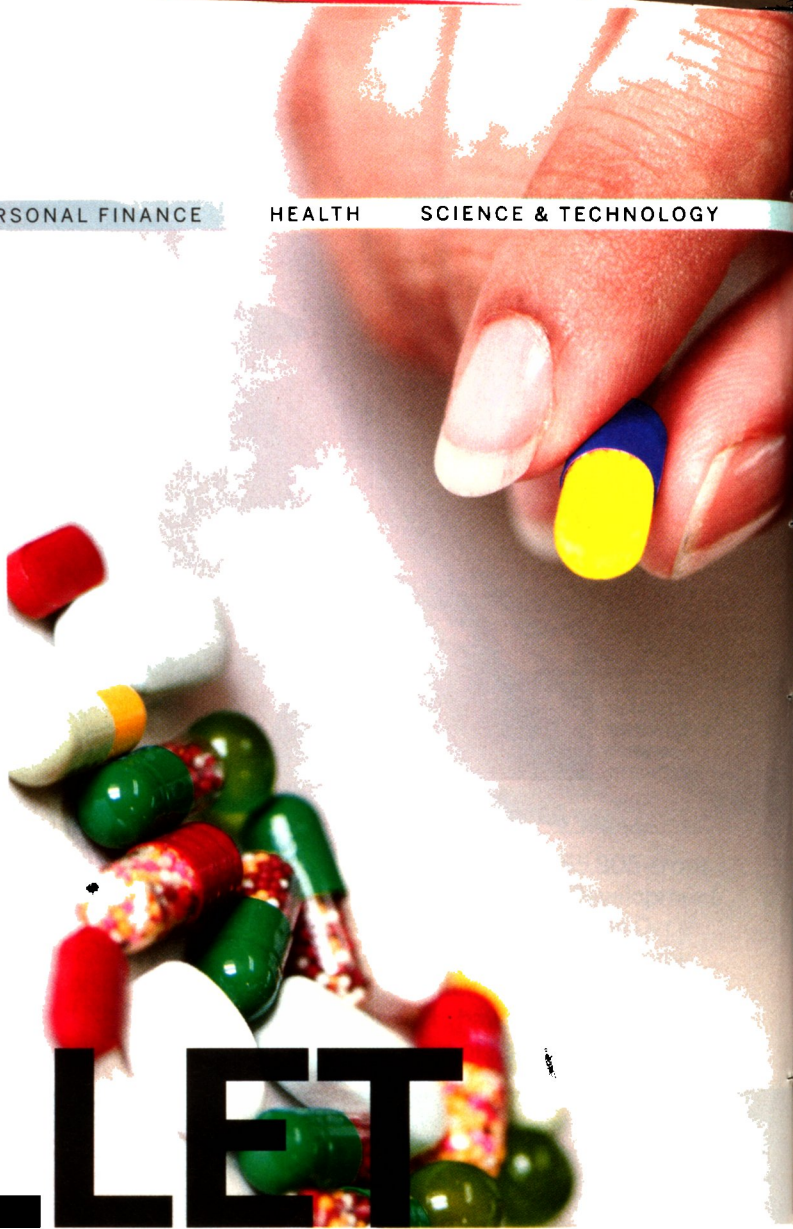


| By Damayanti Datta |

A simple idea can change the world. The polypill is a case in point. For most heart patients, popping piles of pills is a depressing daily reality: knock back blood-thinners to put off clots, toss down statins to lower cholesterol, swallow a fistful of beta-blockers, diuretics and ACE inhibitors to simmer down high blood pressure (BP). What if five of these could be packed into one? And what if it could cut cardiovascular disease (CVD) risk drastically? The medical world has been probing such a possibility since 2002. Now a breakthrough by a team of Indian doctors promises to do just that. On March 30, the study was unveiled to a chorus of cheers at the American College of Cardiology in Orlando, Florida, and simultaneously published in *The Lancet*.

Magic BULLET



A team of Indian doctors has hit international headlines for devising a wonder pill to fight heart attacks and stroke. What is the polypill and how will it help us?

"The polypill is a wonderful concept," says Dr Salim Yusuf, a former student of St. John's Medical College (SJMC) in Bangalore, who now teaches at McMaster University and heads the Population Health Research Institute in Canada. "The results project that the pill is likely to reduce coronary heart disease by 62 per cent and stroke by 48 per cent." But the road to success was not quick and easy. "Would a combo pill be as effective as its components, would it be tolerated, would unexpected interactions

arise?" says Dr Prem Pais, dean and professor of medicine at SJMC. "We designed The Indian Polycap Study (TIPS) to address these questions," adds the man who also heads the clinical trials division at St. John's Research Institute, Bangalore.

Heart disease is the leading cause of death worldwide. Compared to all other countries, India suffers the highest loss in potentially productive years of life due to deaths from CVD in people between age 35 and 64—slated to rise from 9.2 million years

lost in 2000 to 17.9 by 2030. The burden of CVD has risen six-fold in urban and two-fold in rural India over the past four decades. About 29.8 million people were estimated to have coronary heart disease in India in 2003, projected to reach 62 million by 2015. The prevalence of stroke is thought to be 203 per one lakh of population among people older than 20 years. "Given this reality, the polypill has obvious appeal and vast implications," says Dr Denis Xavier of SJMC and a co-investigator of the TIPS trial.